

Chapter 74-1

It was raining again.

The air was humid when she woke up in the morning, and withered yellow leaves had fallen all over the ground, as if reminding people that late autumn had arrived.

Haizhou City had particularly many rainy days, probably because it was close to the sea.

The autumn rain fell continuously and lingering, coming every few days.

Liang Shi took a cardigan from the closet and put it on, then left the room's window open to let some fresh air into the bedroom.

After getting up, she first looked at apartments on the app, constantly feeling that moving was imminent.

It was just a pure intuition.

Or perhaps it was because once she had this matter on her mind, she would keep thinking about it until it was done.

The better listings would get snatched up as soon as they appeared, while Liang Shi didn't want the worse ones.

She had also contacted several agents, all just like last night—they made everything sound wonderful over the phone, but when she went to see the places in person, they turned out to be both expensive and small.

The main thing was that Liang Shi wanted to find a place with good value for money.

If it were just herself, she could make do with anything.

But now she needed to live together with Xu Qingzhu, so they needed at least three bedrooms and one living room—one bedroom each, plus a study for Xu Qingzhu. Finding this kind of apartment near Xu Qingzhu's company would inevitably not be cheap.

Most importantly, there were no apartments that met her expectations.

However, this morning, Liang Shi saw two listings on the app that looked quite good in the photos, so she quickly contacted the agent.

She made an appointment with the agent to view the apartments at noon.

When she mentioned this to Xu Qingzhu during their meal, Xu Qingzhu replied, "You decide. I'm going out today."

Liang Shi nodded. "Then I'll send you a message later."

Xu Qingzhu suddenly paused. "Can't you judge for yourself? You don't need to tell me everything."

Liang Shi was taken aback. "Huh?"

In Xu Qingzhu's eyes, this expression seemed somewhat hurt.

Xu Qingzhu added, "What I mean is you can decide on your own. I don't have any particular requirements."

"But you'll be living there too." Liang Shi said, "So I should ask for your opinion."

"I trust your judgment." Xu Qingzhu took a bite of bread and said with her mouth full, "You don't need to worry about the rent. It's fine if it's a bit more expensive—we can split it."

"No need." Liang Shi immediately said, "I have money."

"How much?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "....."

She felt like Xu Qingzhu was prying into her private savings.

Liang Shi didn't answer directly and instead glossed over the question.

But Xu Qingzhu said to her, "Teacher Liang, I'm confident in your ability to handle things. Just go with what you like. There's no need to always..."

She paused there, then smiled before saying, "...accommodate me."

"I'm not." Liang Shi replied, "It's not about accommodating you."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "Hm?"

"It's about choosing the best option." Liang Shi said, "Besides, this is a place we're going to live in together, so we should discuss and decide together."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Alright."

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Liang Shi felt that discussion was the beginning of an equal relationship.

But clearly, Xu Qingzhu didn't particularly care about such small matters, and moreover, she hoped Liang Shi could handle this on her own.

In that moment, Liang Shi suddenly realized that she had subconsciously taken Xu Qingzhu under her wing, expecting to build a long-term and lasting relationship with her.

Yet Xu Qingzhu seemed ready to leave at any time.

Through their time together, Liang Shi had discovered that Xu Qingzhu was a sufficiently rational person. This trait made her coldness carry a hint of gentleness.

It gave people the illusion that they were very close.

She was very intelligent, so she wouldn't let herself fall into overly complicated or embarrassing situations.

Although the divorce they had mentioned before hadn't been brought up again, she remembered it.

And she was waiting for an appropriate time to divorce her.

Of course, Liang Shi was also waiting for the right time to divorce.

Waiting until she got her body back, until Xu Qingzhu's business empire took shape, or until the legitimate Alpha who could protect Xu Qingzhu appeared—then she would dutifully play her role as cannon fodder and exit the story according to its development.

That was what she had thought back then.

But now...

Her actions seemed to have deviated from her original train of thought.

Xu Qingzhu's attitude today suddenly woke her up—she seemed to have begun expecting things she shouldn't expect.

But Liang Shi's original intention wasn't like this. She simply felt that a place where two people were going to live together should satisfy both of them, which was why she had wanted Xu Qingzhu to look at apartments with her.

Xu Qingzhu probably felt that she wouldn't be living in this apartment for long, so she could just go along with whatever Liang Shi decided.

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Because of that morning conversation, Liang Shi was absent-minded all morning.

When Li Ran came to ask her for the proofread manuscript, she had to call her twice before Liang Shi came back to her senses and hurriedly handed over the manuscript.

But after Li Ran flipped through two pages, she said helplessly, "You gave me the wrong one."

Liang Shi searched through her desk again, found the one she wanted and handed it over, apologizing awkwardly, "Sorry, Sister Ran."

"Why are you so down?" Li Ran asked casually while flipping through the manuscript. "Did you have a fight with your wife?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She shook her head. "No."

Li Ran glanced at her, then pointed at her own eyes and said, "These eyes of mine have seen too many young couples. Right now, your face is written all over with—I'm not happy!"

"That doesn't necessarily mean it's because of my wife." Liang Shi re-tied her messy hair. "Alright, go get busy."

"Really?" Li Ran didn't believe it. "I've seen plenty of people going through heartbreak, and they all had your expression."

Liang Shi: "....."

"What's going on?" Li Ran asked. "Your wife is so beautiful—how could you two even get into a fight?"

"We didn't fight." Liang Shi said, "It's just..."

She paused, finding she didn't know where to begin, and sighed helplessly. "Alright Sister Ran, go get busy."

Li Ran still wanted to gossip a bit more, but Zhou Li in front turned around. "Where's the manuscript due this week?"

Li Ran immediately scurried away.

After a while, Zhou Li handed a new file to Liang Shi. "Can you handle this?"

Liang Shi nodded. "Of course."

"If you need time to calm down, I can give it to someone else." Zhou Li said coldly.

Liang Shi took the file directly from her hand. "Don't listen to Sister Ran's nonsense. I'm fine."

Zhou Li glanced at her and said nothing.

Because of Liang Shi's recommendation, Zhou Li had become the magazine department's director, and she was also concurrently serving as the editing team's leader. After hiring several new employees, the magazine department could finally operate smoothly.

The sales of their first digital issue were fairly good, but a bi-weekly publication was extremely difficult. Every month they had to come up with two new themes, then rush through invitations, interviews, styling, going to the factory... every step was unfamiliar to them.

Moreover, the new employees still needed time to work together smoothly.

The previous director always wasted time on useless things. After Zhou Li became director, she was concise and clear in her work, placing everyone in suitable positions, and efficiency improved dramatically.

Liang Shi's workload wasn't heavy—at least compared to the other employees in the magazine department.

So she didn't have that much time to wallow in melancholy. It was just that her mood was still somewhat low while working, and she couldn't muster any enthusiasm no matter what.

Only after finishing the work at hand did she contact Zhao Xuning: 【Is that apartment of yours still available?】

By lunchtime, Zhao Xuning replied: 【Still available. Moving?】

Liang Shi: 【Yeah, want to take a look.】

Zhao Xuning: 【Tonight?】

Liang Shi: 【Sure.】

Zhao Xuning concisely replied with an "OK" gesture and quickly ended the conversation.

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Zhao Xuning's apartment was in Linjiang District, with an excellent location.

Driving to Minghui would only take about twenty minutes, which counted as a very short commute.

The two apartments Liang Shi went to see with the agent at noon were still barely satisfactory—one had a terrible residential complex environment, and the other had a poor layout where the bedroom couldn't even get any sunlight.

She could only place her hopes on Zhao Xuning's apartment.

If she had any other choice, she wouldn't have contacted Zhao Xuning.

Monetary debts were easy to repay, but debts of gratitude were not.

But then she thought again—after all, the favors she owed Zhao Xuning were already more than just a little.

Between her and Dr. Zhao, there was no need for formalities.

So she drove to Linjiang District after work with peace of mind and successfully found the place Zhao Xuning had mentioned.

When she arrived, there was no one around, so she sent Zhao Xuning a message.

Zhao Xuning said she would be there soon.

But this "soon" turned out to be a full half hour.

Liang Shi: "....."

She stood there playing Snake, played until she scored over a hundred thousand points, until her phone was hot and her fingers were numb.

Only then did the fashionably late Zhao Xuning finally arrive.

Without her white coat, Zhao Xuning was still wearing a button-up shirt and long pants, with white canvas shoes on her feet.

However, she wasn't wearing glasses today, which made her seem even more cold and aloof, lacking her usual refined-but-roguish air.¹

After she walked over, Liang Shi caught a faint whiff of alcohol and asked casually, "Have you been drinking?"

Zhao Xuning nodded. "Had a little."

"Didn't you just get off work?" Liang Shi was puzzled. "Your hospital lets you drink at work?"

"Drank after getting off." Zhao Xuning answered her while leading her into the residential complex.

This belonged to the category of high-end residential complexes. The security was quite good—entering the building door and elevator required facial recognition and fingerprint locks. Whether it was the complex's landscaping or the hygiene of the public areas inside the building, everything was quite nice.

Zhao Xuning led her all the way up to the top floor, the 36th floor.

Two units per floor, Zhao Xuning's place was the one on the left—over 160 square meters, three bedrooms, one living room, and two bathrooms. It completely met Liang Shi's requirements.

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After touring the apartment, Liang Shi stood by the window looking at the river view.

All the lights along both sides of the river had lit up. On the bridge, traffic flowed continuously. The ripples on the water flowed along with the colors of the lights, and when the wind blew, the water sparkled.

Footnotes:

¹ "斯文敗類" (sīwén bàilèi) - Literally "refined scoundrel" or "elegant rogue." This Chinese internet slang describes someone who appears cultured, refined, and scholarly on the outside, but is actually quite roguish or "bad" in an attractive way. It's often used to describe someone with a contrast between their gentle, intellectual appearance and a more mischievous or seductive personality underneath.

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"Dr. Zhao, are you really going to rent this apartment to me?" Liang Shi was a bit in disbelief.

"Lending it to you as a transition." Zhao Xuning said, "Move out once you've bought your own place."

"Why did you buy this apartment in the first place?" Liang Shi opened the window. It had just rained, and even the air carried a coolness, but the breeze felt very comfortable. "As an investment?"

Zhao Xuning was silent for a moment. "No."

"Then why did you buy it?" Liang Shi was surprised. "Could it be a marital home? But your family would definitely buy you a villa."

"No." Zhao Xuning denied again.

Afraid that Liang Shi would ask more questions, Zhao Xuning explained, "I lived here with my girlfriend when I was in university."

Liang Shi: ".....??"

No one could resist gossip!

Even someone as zen and steady as Liang Shi subconsciously lit up. "Was it the one I saw at the hospital last time?"

Zhao Xuning responded softly, "Mm."

"So you two were university classmates?" Liang Shi sighed with emotion. "How nice, a campus romance."

"You never dated?" Zhao Xuning asked back.

Liang Shi shook her head. "Would you believe me if I said I never went to university?"

Zhao Xuning was stunned for a moment, then said, "I already told you not to tell me about things from your side."

Liang Shi: "....."

That fear of getting into trouble came up again.

But seeing her like this, Liang Shi found it funny and deliberately teased her. "Then I'll tell you anyway."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"I actually bought a place." Liang Shi said, "It was also a river-view apartment, but now it's all gone."

Zhao Xuning: ".....Serves you right."

"What kind of thing is that to say?" Liang Shi scoffed lightly. "Dr. Zhao, you really don't know the hardships of life."

"As if you do." Zhao Xuning called out sarcastically, "Third Young Miss Liang."

"Of course I do." Liang Shi said, "I started from nothing too, you know? Before I entered the entertainment industry, I had nothing—I rented a basement, then a semi-basement, then shared a place with others. Only after I made money from filming did I upgrade my living situation."

"Fishing for sympathy?" Zhao Xuning glanced at her sideways.

Liang Shi shook her head. "What's pitiful about that? I'm just chatting. Since I came here, you're the first person who can listen to me talk about these things."

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Although Zhao Xuning still felt that Liang Shi might be mentally disturbed, seeing her speak so confidently couldn't help but make her waver a little. But after a few seconds, Zhao Xuning would once again firmly believe that Liang Shi was indeed mentally disturbed.

"So what did you gain from entering the entertainment industry?" Zhao Xuning continued along with her words.

"Money and fans." Liang Shi said, "Oh right, I also won Best Actress."

Zhao Xuning's eyelid twitched, and she praised expressionlessly, "Impressive."

Liang Shi: "....."

She lost her desire to share and instead complained, "You're just humoring me."

Zhao Xuning nodded. "As long as you can tell."

Liang Shi: "?"

Liang Shi asked Zhao Xuning very sincerely, "Dr. Zhao, with your annoying personality, how did you manage to find such an excellent girlfriend?"

Zhao Xuning: "....."

Zhao Xuning closed the window, her voice colder than the autumn wind outside. "She just liked that I was annoying."

"But you still broke up in the end." Liang Shi blurted out subconsciously, then quickly tried to make amends. "I didn't mean to insult you."

Zhao Xuning glanced at her sideways. "How is that any different from insulting someone?"

Liang Shi: "....."

In the end, Liang Shi decided not to exchange barbs with Zhao Xuning anymore, after all, the other party was about to become her landlord.

This apartment was currently the best choice for her, so she communicated with Zhao Xuning very "amicably."

An apartment that hadn't been lived in for too long appeared lifeless, but all the rooms were decorated in warm tones, which was extremely inconsistent with the current aloof flower Dr. Zhao.¹

Especially the master bedroom.

The wallpaper was a girlish pink, completely at odds with Dr. Zhao's image.

It was hard to imagine what Dr. Zhao was like when she was in a relationship.

Footnotes:

¹ "高嶺之花" (gāolǐng zhī huā) - Literally "flower on a high peak." This is a term used to describe someone who is beautiful and admirable but seems unapproachable or out of reach, like a flower growing on a tall mountain that one can only admire from afar but never pick.

Chapter 74-5

While Zhao Xuning was making a phone call in the living room, Liang Shi carefully looked around the master bedroom, and then discovered carvings in a hidden spot behind the nightstand: Zhao Xuning & Shen Hui.

It should have been carved with a small knife, each stroke extremely careful.

To see more clearly, Liang Shi moved the nightstand aside.

Then she discovered a blue envelope under the nightstand, with "To Zhao Xuning" written on it.

The envelope was still unopened. Liang Shi hesitated for a moment but didn't open it, only dusting off the top.

It seemed like only couples deeply in love would do this kind of thing.

Carving two people's names together made them seem especially close, as if the indelible marks represented spending a lifetime together.

Liang Shi raised her hand to wipe the dust off the wall, revealing the true appearance of that line of text, only to discover there was a heart before and after both names.

Childish, but innocent.

When Zhao Xuning came in, what she saw was Liang Shi having moved the nightstand aside, half-squatting on the ground wiping the wall.

Zhao Xuning: "....."

"What are you doing?" Zhao Xuning walked in and asked.

Liang Shi handed her the envelope. "There's a letter for you here. It fell under the nightstand."

Zhao Xuning was stunned when she saw the envelope, then hesitated about whether to open it.

Liang Shi said, "Could it be a breakup letter from your ex-girlfriend?"

"No." Zhao Xuning denied directly.

Their breakup had been too ugly. Shen Hui wouldn't have written her a letter.

The time spent in this apartment was all the most beautiful moments between her and Shen Hui.

Their university was the nearby medical school. Both of them were somewhat germaphobic, so they didn't want to live on campus. From meeting to dating, it was only a month before Zhao Xuning bought this apartment. The two of them naturally stayed overnight here and moved in to live together.

"Then open it and see." Liang Shi urged. "What if you missed some important information?"

Zhao Xuning lowered her eyes, her hands trembling slightly as she opened the letter.

Although she roughly knew in her heart what it was, she was still a bit afraid to face it.

She carefully opened it, then unfolded the slightly yellowed paper.

On the paper was elegant small regular script,¹ filling an entire page with: "Wife, I was wrong."

Densely packed, and Shen Hui, who had mild OCD, had aligned all the characters neatly.

Among this entire page of "Wife, I was wrong," two different ones were mixed in.

One was "Ningning wife, mwah."

And another was: "Wife, I love you."

Seeing such a childish letter again after so many years, Zhao Xuning felt a sour ache in her heart.

This should have been from when Shen Hui went to have dinner with a junior from the same department, and when Zhao Xuning went to pick her up, she found that junior clinging to Shen Hui's shoulder. Back then, Shen Hui was far from as assertive as she was now, and Zhao Xuning didn't know that Shen Hui was actually the famous second daughter of the Shen family in Haizhou City—she still thought she was a simple and pure person.

That junior had almost kissed Shen Hui's face. Zhao Xuning brought her home that night and was so angry she drank two glasses of wine.

Someone who normally didn't drink at all became dizzy after drinking too much. On the bed, she held Shen Hui and kept saying, "You're mine—no one can take you away."

Shen Hui coaxed her, "I'm yours, I'm yours, no one can take me away."

But then Shen Hui still messaged that junior at night, asking if she got home safely. When Zhao Xuning later discovered this, Shen Hui explained that she needed to ensure the junior's personal safety.

Zhao Xuning was incredibly jealous at the time. She pinched Shen Hui's waist, pressed her onto the soft bed, and kissed her until she could barely breathe.

Their long hair tangled together on the bed. The drunk Zhao Xuning was unreasonable. "I'm angry... so angry."

To coax her, Shen Hui said she would write her an apology letter.

But later when Zhao Xuning woke up with a splitting headache, she felt her behavior that night was too childish and didn't bring it up.

Yet Shen Hui told her she had written the apology letter, but didn't know where it went.

Zhao Xuning said she was making excuses and hadn't written it at all.

Shen Hui searched the entire home but couldn't find it.

Unexpectedly, years later, it was found by Liang Shi under the nightstand in the master bedroom.

Zhao Xuning looked at the words in the letter, and each character seemed to come alive.

Back then, if Shen Hui had an early class, she would definitely wake Zhao Xuning up. After waking her, afraid of her morning temper, she would quickly lean over to kiss her, putting her hand on her waist and acting coquettish, "Wife, give me a kiss."

If Zhao Xuning had an early class, she would always say the day before, "Don't wake me up, and don't kiss me when you wake up in the morning."

Yet every time, Zhao Xuning would secretly kiss her, then prepare breakfast before going to her early class.

On the bed they had picked out together, on the sofa, in the kitchen, in every corner of this apartment—they had left traces of joy.

Shen Hui would always sit on the living room sofa watching TV, then wait for Zhao Xuning to bring her cut fruit. After only a few bites, she would wrap her legs around Zhao Xuning's waist, wanting her to carry her into the bedroom.

Back then, Shen Hui had baby fat on her face, and her body was also plump, with curves in all the right places.

She had a first-love face² and a good personality, and many people at school liked her.

Getting jealous was a daily task for Zhao Xuning, but Shen Hui always coaxed her.

Footnotes:

¹ "小楷" (xiǎo kǎi) - Small regular script, a style of Chinese calligraphy characterized by neat, small, and elegant characters. It's considered a refined and beautiful handwriting style.

² "初戀臉" (chūliàn liǎn) - Literally "first love face." This is a Chinese internet term describing someone who has an innocent, sweet, and pure appearance that reminds people of their first love—typically featuring soft, youthful features that evoke feelings of nostalgia and innocent romance.

Chapter 74-6

Shen Hui's tone of voice would rise at the end, carrying a hint of teasing, "My darling wife is angry again."

"Zhao Xuning, don't be mad anymore."

"Ningning wife, come here for a kiss, don't be angry anymore, okay?"

"Wife, I was wrong... really wrong."

"Ningning wife, let me prepare a gift for you."

"....."

Zhao Xuning was the unmovable aloof flower of the school, always alone year after year, without many friends, with only Shen Hui by her side.

Looking back, during those days of dating, it had always been Shen Hui accommodating her.

What she had done for Shen Hui seemed insignificant.

Back then, she still had the arrogance of a spirited youth, having been spoiled by those around her since childhood.

She came from an excellent family background and was also beautiful. There were quite a few girls who gave her love letters.

So there was no need to treat Shen Hui too well—she would love her anyway.

Moreover, she clearly knew that she and Shen Hui probably couldn't get married.

Her parents would never accept her marrying someone without any background.

From the day she could start dating, the concept her parents had instilled in her was that dating could be casual, but marriage must be with someone of equal social standing.¹

At first, she was just playing around. After dating for two years, during a meal, she took the initiative to mention to her parents that she might marry a girl without much background in the future.

Her father flew into a rage, and a shard from the bowl he threw cut the side of her neck.

When she returned here, Shen Hui treated her wound and said to her, "Wife, give me a kiss, it won't hurt after a kiss."

.....

It seemed like all the beautiful memories happened here.

Every word Shen Hui had once written for her was so vivid, automatically read out in Shen Hui's tender and coquettish voice.

Back then, she wasn't yet covered in thorns.

When did things start to change?

Between them...

Footnotes:

¹ "門當戶對" (mén dāng hù duì) - A traditional Chinese concept meaning that marriage should be between families of equal social and economic status. Literally referring to the decorative elements on doors and gates that indicated a family's status, this phrase emphasizes that partners should come from similar backgrounds in terms of wealth, education, and social standing.

Chapter 74-7

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"Dr. Zhao." Liang Shi waved her hand in front of Zhao Xuning's eyes, and only then did Zhao Xuning stop her chaotic reminiscing and come back to her senses, responding, "What is it?"

"You're asking me what's wrong?" Liang Shi asked, "What's wrong with you? You're crying."

"Was there something touching written on this letter?" Liang Shi said, "Your tears have soaked into it."

Zhao Xuning hurriedly raised her hand to wipe away the marks, but Liang Shi stopped her. "You'll tear it if you do that."

Only then did Zhao Xuning stop. She folded the paper, put it back into the envelope, turned around and wiped her tears, saying softly, "I'm fine."

Liang Shi suddenly asked, "How many years did you date your girlfriend?"

Zhao Xuning clutched that letter tightly in her hand. "Six years."

Four years of university, two years while studying abroad. In her third year abroad, Shen Hui got pregnant, had a miscarriage, and also misunderstood that she had cheated. Shen Hui ended her studies early and was taken back to the country by her family.

It was only at the hospital that she learned Shen Hui wasn't just some ordinary girl—she was the second young miss of the Shen family.

That day, Shen Hui lay on the bed as if all her vitality had been drained away.

Zhao Xuning apologized endlessly, but it was all in vain.

Just like that, they broke up.

After that, she never saw Shen Hui again, and she knew Shen Hui would never forgive her.

Shen Hui had an extremely severe obsession with purity in relationships—she was someone who would never give others a second chance.

What the truth of that night actually was no longer mattered.

What mattered was that Shen Hui saw her tangled in bed with another woman, even though nothing substantial had happened that day.

Zhao Xuning regretted countless times—why hadn't she been more vigilant?

Why did she fall into someone else's trap?

Her last year abroad was spent in a daze, drowning her sorrows in alcohol every day in the apartment they had rented, getting completely drunk.

It wasn't until close to her return to the country that she managed to pull herself together.

The past couldn't be revisited—once remembered, it was heart-piercing, bone-eroding pain.

After saying the words "six years," Zhao Xuning finally realized just how many days she and Shen Hui had spent together.

In all her lonely days, it was Shen Hui who had kept her company.

"Couldn't make it past the seven-year itch, huh." ¹ Liang Shi sighed with emotion. "You two must have been very happy once."

Zhao Xuning nodded sluggishly. "Yes."

After saying this, Zhao Xuning pressed her lips together. "Sorry, this..."

"I won't rent this apartment." Liang Shi spoke before her. "If we moved in, wouldn't we be overwriting the beautiful memories you two once had?"

Zhao Xuning took a deep breath. "Sorry."

"What's there to be sorry about?" Liang Shi patted her shoulder. "You being willing to lend me an apartment is already like sending charcoal in snowy weather, ² okay? Now that you can't rent it out, that's the most normal thing in the world."

Zhao Xuning said, "The 10th floor of this building is also mine. If you don't mind it being small, you can live there."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Dr. Zhao, are you like a cunning rabbit with three burrows?" ³ Liang Shi joked to ease the awkward atmosphere.

Zhao Xuning smiled lightly. "I just happened to see someone selling it, thought the price was right so I bought it. Because Shen Hui's birthday is in October, and she really liked this residential complex."

"Hey." Liang Shi suddenly thought of something. "Between you and Shen Hui, who's older?"

"She's two years older than me." Zhao Xuning said.

"Then how old are you?" Liang Shi followed up.

Zhao Xuning: "Twenty-five."

Liang Shi: ".....???"

Liang Shi was stunned, feeling like she hadn't heard clearly. "What did you say?"

Zhao Xuning: ".....Twenty-five."

"We're the same age?" Liang Shi asked in astonishment.

"Obviously." Zhao Xuning rolled her eyes. "We were in the same class in elementary school."

"But the thing is, I..." Liang Shi was a bit incoherent. "This body—she only graduated a few years ago. You... why are you already a doctor?"

"I skipped grades." Zhao Xuning said as if it were nothing. "Skipped two grades in middle school, one grade in high school."

Liang Shi: "....."

Alright.

The world of geniuses was always different from ordinary people.

Zhao Xuning was twenty-five this year and had already dated Shen Hui for six years—didn't that mean she had started dating Shen Hui right when she became an adult?

It really was hard to forget.

"Then why don't you and Shen Hui get back together?" Liang Shi asked. "You obviously still love her."

"She doesn't love me anymore." Zhao Xuning said.

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi, who had been single since birth, didn't know how to comfort Zhao Xuning either. She could only let her adjust her emotions on her own. Then they went downstairs to look at Zhao Xuning's apartment on the tenth floor.

That apartment had a strong minimalist style.⁴ After the renovation was completed, not a single day had anyone lived in it—Zhao Xuning had purely bought it just to look at.

However, this one was indeed much smaller than the one upstairs—just over eighty square meters, two bedrooms and one living room, one kitchen and one bathroom.

No extra study room.

But fortunately, it was still a river-view apartment. Liang Shi even asked Zhao Xuning how much this apartment cost.

Zhao Xuning said over four million.

Liang Shi silently calculated in her head—the housing price here was over forty thousand per square meter.

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That was still acceptable.

Liang Shi planned that once she got used to living here, she would buy a slightly bigger apartment in this residential complex in the future.

Footnotes:

¹ "七年之癢" (qī nián zhī yǎng) - The "seven-year itch," a concept referring to the idea that happiness in a relationship declines after around seven years of marriage or being together, when couples may feel restless or dissatisfied.

² "雪中送炭" (xuě zhōng sòng tàn) - Literally "sending charcoal in snowy weather." A Chinese idiom meaning to provide help when someone desperately needs it, like giving warmth to someone freezing in the snow.

³ "狡兔三窟" (jiǎo tù sān kū) - Literally "a cunning rabbit has three burrows." A Chinese idiom meaning a clever person always has multiple backup plans or escape routes. Here, Liang Shi is teasing Zhao Xuning for owning multiple properties.

⁴ "性冷淡風" (xìng lěngdàn fēng) - Literally "sexually cold/frigid style." Despite the literal meaning, this is actually a popular Chinese internet term for minimalist aesthetic design—characterized by neutral colors, clean lines, and simple, uncluttered spaces. The term was borrowed from fashion and interior design trends.

Chapter 74-8

After deciding on the apartment, Liang Shi subconsciously took out her phone to tell Xu Qingzhu, to ask if renting this apartment was okay.

But just as she took it out, she remembered what Xu Qingzhu had said that morning: "Just decide on your own."

She hesitated.

Zhao Xuning noticed her hesitant posture while holding the phone and raised an eyebrow. "Aren't you going to ask Xu Qingzhu's opinion?"

Liang Shi stood there, turned off her phone screen, thought for a few seconds with some conflict, then asked Zhao Xuning, "Say, if someone lets you handle everything and says you don't need to ask for her opinion—that you'd better just handle it all yourself—what does that mean?"

"Xu Qingzhu said that?" Zhao Xuning asked back.

Liang Shi nodded. "She said I don't need to ask her opinion about renting an apartment. Does that mean she doesn't plan to live here for long?"

Zhao Xuning felt something was off listening to this, so she asked her to explain in detail.

Liang Shi then told her about the conversation from that morning, as well as going to look at apartments together last night.

After listening, Zhao Xuning analyzed very "wisely": "She probably thinks you have no opinions of your own."

Liang Shi: "?"

"But isn't it normal for two people to discuss things together?" Liang Shi asked.

"But Xu Qingzhu is very busy right now. You bother her about everything, can't make any decisions on your own." Zhao Xuning said, "Isn't that having no opinions of your own?"

Liang Shi: "....."

"Xu Qingzhu has never really liked people without their own opinions." Zhao Xuning added.

Liang Shi: "....."

She felt like she had been viciously stabbed.

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In fact, Xu Qingzhu didn't mean it that way at all.

She simply felt that Liang Shi was being too cautious when asking her things. Perhaps because she had encountered quite a lot of things recently, Liang Shi was afraid of upsetting her, and every time would look at her with very careful eyes.

This made Xu Qingzhu feel somewhat embarrassed.

Besides, she wasn't a particularly fragile person—she could regulate most of her emotions on her own.

The greatest confusion of her life had been this marriage with Liang Shi, and those days of being trapped in the marriage, wallowing in self-pity and suffering.

At other times, she maintained herself very well.

Xu Qingzhu just wanted Liang Shi to pick what she herself liked, rather than always deferring to her opinions.

As a result, that evening she saw a message from Zhao Xuning, asking if she thought the current Liang Shi was too indecisive.

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

At that moment, she had just finished working overtime and was in the elevator. She typed out a long paragraph, about to send it to explain, when she received a call from Liang Shi just as she stepped out of the elevator.

Xu Qingzhu answered, "Hello?"

There was no response from the other end of the phone, only very noisy sounds.

Liang Shi's voice came through, carrying a hint of drunkenness: "How am I indecisive? I used to be a very decisive person. This is my respect for her, isn't it? Shouldn't it be? Why are people so hard to understand?"

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

Zhao Xuning's voice also sounded a bit floaty. "You can't ask about everything, right? Some things you can ask about, some things you can't. If you ask about everything, it's like an elementary school student tattling to their parents—who would like that?"

"Then what can I ask about? What can't I ask about?" Liang Shi asked.

"Don't ask about things she doesn't like." Zhao Xuning said.

Liang Shi's voice suddenly rose. "Then how do I know what she likes?!"

Zhao Xuning chuckled lightly. "Then just ask."

"But you just said some things can't be asked about."

"....."

Two people who sounded completely drunk were discussing some mysterious relationship question. Even Xu Qingzhu found it funny listening to them.

After she hung up, she called Zhao Xuning again. It took two tries before the call went through.

When Zhao Xuning answered, she said, "That one of yours—I called a designated driver to send her back. Don't worry."

"You're not drunk?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning paused for a moment. "How could I be drunk? I can drink a thousand cups without falling."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

Alright, she was definitely drunk.

"Do you need me to call a designated driver for you?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning immediately refused, speaking with extreme certainty: "No need. I'll find my wife."

Xu Qingzhu was startled. "Your wife? Since when do you have a wife?"

"I've had one for a long time." Zhao Xuning said, "We even have a child."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She suspected Zhao Xuning wasn't drunk, but had gone crazy.

If Zhao Xuning remembered what she said tonight tomorrow morning, she would probably want to bash her head against the ground.

The very humanitarian Xu Qingzhu sighed. "Then go find her. Let me know you're safe after you get home."

Zhao Xuning said seriously: "Okay."

As soon as she finished speaking, Zhao Xuning hung up the phone.

Without a moment's hesitation.

Xu Qingzhu adjusted the bag on her shoulder, thinking about whether to explain this morning's words to Liang Shi when she got back tonight.

But then it occurred to her belatedly that Liang Shi was already a drunk—she probably wouldn't understand even if she explained.

There weren't many people in the office building at this hour. After Xu Qingzhu went outside, she found her car, unlocked it, and the car lights flashed twice.

As she walked to her car and was about to get in, a tall person in a black suit walked over and said respectfully, "Hello, Miss Xu. Our CEO Su would like to invite you to have a chat in his car."

Xu Qingzhu was startled. "CEO Su? Which CEO Su?"

The other person paused, hesitating about how to introduce him, when a deep voice sounded: "It's me."

Xu Qingzhu turned to look—it was a face she had seen in a magazine before: Su Zhe.

In person, he was slightly thinner than in the magazine. He was dressed like an elite, his hair combed back meticulously. You could tell he had been a handsome man when he was young.

His features didn't look much like Su Yao's, but Sheng Yu, whom she had met that day, did resemble him a little.

Xu Qingzhu's mind raced through many thoughts, but the moment she faced Su Zhe, she put on a professional smile. "So it's CEO Su from Haiwei Jewelry."

Despite her young age, her presence was not lacking at all. She met Su Zhe's gaze without any stage fright. "I've long heard of your great reputation."

"No need for false pleasantries." Su Zhe got directly into her passenger seat. "Let's talk."

Xu Qingzhu hesitated for a moment, then also got into the car.

In the silent car, Xu Qingzhu said coldly, "What do you want to talk to me about?"

Su Zhe didn't beat around the bush either. "Do you want to acknowledge your family?"

"Acknowledge who?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Su Zhe chuckled lightly and said bluntly, "Acknowledge the Su family."